

SKYROOT AEROSPACE

SKYROOT AEROSPACE'S MAIDEN test flight of Vikram-1 on July 18, 2026, was the first time an orbital-class rocket, fully designed and developed by a private player, lifted from Indian soil. "It is the biggest step we have taken. In just over four years we have gone from Vikram-S, India's first private rocket, on a suborbital demonstration, to attempting orbital launch. That is a large leap," Co-founder and CEO Pawan Kumar Chandana tells *BT* in an interview.

A mechanical engineering graduate from IIT Kharagpur, Chandana joined Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) as a scientist in 2012, spending nearly six years working on India's launch vehicle programmes. In 2018, he took the entrepreneurial plunge with Co-founder Naga Bharath Daka, launching Skyroot Aerospace at a time when India had neither a private space policy nor an established funding ecosystem for space start-ups.

Unlike Vikram-S, Vikram-1 is a multi-stage orbital rocket. "Vikram-S validated the foundation. It proved our propulsion systems, our composite structures, and that a private Indian team could build and fly a rocket," says Chandana.

"Vikram-1 is a completely different challenge. It has multiple stages. It has to reach orbital velocity. It is heavier and far more complex. Successfully launching Vikram-1 means proving our actual commercial product. It shows that we can reliably take a customer's satellite and place it in the intended orbit. For customers, that changes us from a promising team into a launch provider they can trust. For investors, it de-risks our path to higher launch cadence and sustained revenue," he says.

Vikram-1's first test flight is a data-gathering mission. "We will be getting real-flight data from every system, which no ground test can give us, and which feeds straight into the vehicles that follow. This will be significant for us and the national space ecosystem," says Chandana.

Skyroot's plan is to establish commercial readiness quickly, through a short series of test flights, and then build cadence.

The second Vikram-1 rocket is already under production. Across Skyroot's two Hyderabad campuses, the company has built manufacturing capacity for one Vikram-1 rocket every month, positioning itself



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for regular commercial launches.

Skyroot expects about two-thirds of its demand to come from international markets. "Roughly two-thirds international and one-third India today, and we expect the international share to remain the majority in the near term, mainly from the US, Japan, Europe and Southeast Asia," says Chandana.

On being asked if Indian space-tech start-ups are competing with ISRO, Chandana says private players are complementing the state-run agency.